Office of Research Assurance

Human Subjects Research Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP - 210: NASA IRB Membership

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Versions
210	08/05/2025	v.5.3	v.5.2

Purpose

HRP – 210 describes the NASA Institutional Review Board (IRB) Membership including member selection, length of service, member responsibilities, and member removal.

The NASA IRB (hereafter referred to as "IRB") ensures the rights and welfare of human subject participation in research through administration of ethical standards and regulatory compliance and oversees all research involving human subjects in which the Agency is engaged (NPR 7100.1).

Policy

1. NASA regulations 14 CFR 1230.107 require the IRB have at least five members with varying backgrounds to promote complete and adequate review of research activities.

   The IRB shall be sufficiently qualified as codified in 14CFR1230.107. Given the IRB shall be able to ascertain the acceptability of proposed research in terms of institutional commitments and regulations, applicable law, and standards of professional conduct and practice, members must include individuals knowledgeable in these areas.

   If the IRB regularly reviews research that involves a category of subjects that is vulnerable to coercion or undue influence, such as children, prisoners, individuals with impaired decision-making capacity, or economically or educationally disadvantaged persons, consideration shall be given to the inclusion of one or more individuals who are knowledgeable about and experience in working with these categories of subjects.

   Additionally, the IRB shall:

   - Include at least one member whose primary concerns are in scientific areas and at least one member whose primary concerns are in nonscientific areas
   - Include at least one member who is not otherwise affiliated with NASA and who is not part of the immediate family of a person who is affiliated with NASA

2. No IRB member may participate in an initial, modification, or continuing review determination vote for which they have a conflicting interest. Conflicted IRB members may participate in the discussion and provide information requested by the IRB. Real or perceived conflicts of interest should be reported to the IRB Office. Conflicts of interest must be reported before IRB review of the conflicted research proposal or as it is identified. All IRB members must complete a "Conflict of Interest Disclosure Statement." (SOP-055)

3. IRB Meetings are closed to the public. At the request of members or the Chair, IRB staff may invite guests to an IRB meeting. All guests, as well as IRB members, are responsible for maintaining the confidentiality of IRB deliberations, discussions, and votes. Care should be taken to store and dispose of meeting materials and protocols should not be discussed with others outside of the IRB.
    a. The IRB may, at its discretion, invite individuals with competence in special areas to assist in the review of issues that require expertise beyond or in addition to that available on the IRB.
4. Prime IRB Members, in addition to the requirements outlined in NASA regulations 14 CFR 1230.107, also include at least one representative from each of the following Centers: Langley, Ames, Johnson, and Kennedy, a crew representative, a crew physician, and a safety representative. All individuals listed above are voting members.
5. Alternate members may replace a prime IRB member as needed. When the prime members are present, an alternate IRB member may not vote.
6. The IRB may also have standing guests attend monthly meetings. Standing guests must be invited by the IRB Chair or their delegate. Standing guests may not vote.
7. IRB Members, both Prime and Alternate, will serve a 3-year term at the discretion of the IRB Chair and may be invited to serve subsequent terms.
8. All NASA primary and alternate IRB members must maintain the Collaborate Institute Training Initiative (CITI) educational certificates assigned.
    a. CITI certificate must state "IRB Member" but considerations will be taken into account for "Biomedical Research" or "Social/Behavioral Research".
9. The IRB Chair, in consultation with the Office of Research Assurance, has the authority to remove an IRB member (prime or alternate) or standing guest at any time in the unlikely event that the member of the IRB or standing guest has conducted themselves in a manner contrary to the policies and ethical and professional responsibilities of the IRB and/or NASA.
10. All NASA primary and alternate IRB members will participate in continuing education opportunities. Continuing education will be provided during at least six meetings per year.

Responsibilities

Responsibilities of the ***NASA IRB primary and alternate Member*** include, but are not limited to:

1. Complete a “Conflict of Interest Disclosure Statement” (SOP-055)
2. Report all real or perceived conflicts of interest before IRB review of the conflicted research proposal or as it is identified
3. Maintain the Collaborate Institute Training Initiative (CITI) educational certificates assigned
4. Attending scheduled monthly IRB meetings
5. If a prime IRB member cannot attend a meeting, they are responsible for informing the IRB chair of the absence at least one week in advance and ensuring their alternate can attend.
6. Review all assigned protocols thoroughly and evaluate them per the applicable Federal regulations and NASA policy in a timely fashion.
7. Participate in meeting discussions, deliberations, and vote when applicable
8. Work collaboratively with researchers, other board members, and the IRB office
9. Seek consultation with IRB chair as needed
10. Report allegations, complaints, and suspected noncompliance to the IRB Chair or their delegate
11. Maintain the confidentiality of IRB protocol reviews, deliberations, discussions, and votes. Care should be taken to store and dispose of meeting materials and protocols should not be discussed with others outside of the IRB.
12. Act as a liaison within their respective department
13. Participate in quality assurance monitoring, as applicable
14. Report attempts to influence IRB decisions to the IRB Chair

Procedures

1. The NASA Office of Research Assurance will coordinate appointments of Center personnel to the IRB with concurrence of the respective Center supervisor and in consultation with the IRB Chair.
2. In the event of a removal, the IRB Chair, in consultation with the Office of Research Assurance, will notify an IRB member (prime or alternate) or standing guest, in writing, that they conducted themselves in a manner contrary to the policies and ethical and professional responsibilities of the IRB and/or NASA.

Definitions

Conflict of Interest (COI): Financial or non-financial; any set of circumstances that creates a risk that professional judgement or actions regarding a primary interest will be unduly influenced by a secondary interest.

Institution [14 CFR 1230.102]: any public or private entity or agency (including federal, states, and other agencies).

IRB: a committee that reviews and monitors research involving human subjects to ensure the ethical, safe, and equitable treatment of the subjects through the application of regulatory requirements and institutional policies. The IRB is guided by three ethical principles outlined in the Belmont Report: respect for persons, beneficence, and justice.

NASA IRB Office: Office staff to include the NASA IRB Chair, IRB Lead, and IRB Coordinator(s).

References

NASA

- 14 CFR 1230.107
- NPR 7100.1

Other

Bankert, E. G. (2022). *Institutional Review Board Management and Function 3rd Edition.* Burlington, MA: Joens & Bartlett Learning.

AAHRPP Tip Sheet 7: Evaluation of IRB Chairs, Vice-Chairs, IRB Members, and IRB Staff

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v.5.3	Minor revisions	C. Roman	M. Covington	05Aug2025
v.5.2	Minor revisions	J. Kisenwether	J. Kisenwether	27March2025
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v.5	Minor revisions	A. Garza	M. Covington	04Feb2025
v.4	Minor revisions	J. Green	M. Covington	14Aug2023
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v.2	Revised Processes	A. Garza	M. Covington	31Jan2023
v.1	Original, reviewed by J. Christensen	J. Kisenwether	M. Covington	06Jul2020